On the other hand, in the sentence *The fish is eaten by the cat*, the (grammatical) subject is *the fish* (since it displays concord with the verb), while the (prepositional) object is *the cat*. Nevertheless, from a purely semantic point of view, the agent is still *the cat* (it is still the cat that performs the action), while *the fish* is the patient.

Thus, we can consider the subject and object as *syntactic* arguments (which depend strictly on the sentence structure), while agent and patient are *semantic* arguments (they do not depend on the sentence structure, but strictly on the meaning of it).

Some languages can mark the argument of an intransitive verb either as a patient or as an agent. The choice is made by the speaker based on semantic considerations. The agentive marking (i.e., the argument of the intransitive verb is marked as agent) is used to show that the action is undertaken by the subject, while the patientive marking is used to show that the action is rather undergone by the subject.

For example, in English this patientive marking is usually implied by using the structures *to get X* (e.g., *to get lost*, *to get drowned*, etc.). Another example is verbs that indicate accidental actions, for which a patientive marking would probably be favoured (*to fall*, *to trip*, etc.).

This type of marking is usually referred to as *fluid-S* alignment (which is a type of morphosyntactic alignment, as shown in the next chapter). There are two subtypes of fluid-S alignment:

- *Agentive-default* in which the "default" (neutral) way of marking the intransitive argument is as agent. In this case, the patientive marking is used to highlight a lack of volition / control.
- *Patientive-default* on the other hand, uses patient marking as default. By using the agentive marking, the speaker highlights a certain degree of volition / control.

Problem 6.6

Tabasaran (Yakov Testelets, MSK 1998)

Here are some verbal forms in Tabasaran and their English translations. The verb endings have been separated from the verb root with a hyphen.

bisun-čačʷu	‘we caught you$_{\text{PL}}$’	*ilbicun-za*	‘I turned’
ʁapun-čʷa	‘you$_{\text{PL}}$ said’	*kčʷuχun-vu*	‘you$_{\text{SG}}$ slipped’
ʁarʁun-zu	‘I froze’	*kčʷuχun-za*	‘I sleighed’
ʁiliχun-čʷa	‘you$_{\text{PL}}$ worked’	*uldugun-zu*	‘I got lost’
ʁipʼun-za	‘I ate’	*ursun-čʷa*	‘you$_{\text{PL}}$ jumped’
ʁurčːʷun-vazu	‘you$_{\text{SG}}$ beat me’	*qergun-zu*	‘I woke up’
daqun-za	‘I stretched’	*šadʁaxun-čʷu*	‘you$_{\text{PL}}$ got happy’
duʁmišʁaxun-zu	‘I was born’	*ergun-vu*	‘you$_{\text{SG}}$ got tired’

Problem 6.6a You are given some additional verb roots:

aqun = ‘to fall’, *ʁilirqʼun* = ‘to get scared’, *učʼʷun* = ‘to enter’

Translate into English:

1. *aqun-za*
2. *aqun-zu*
3. *bisun-čʷazu*
4. *ʁilirqʼun-ču*
5. *učʼʷun-va*

Problem 6.6b You are given some additional verb roots:

ʁalrʁun = ‘to inflate’, *dusun* = ‘to stay’, *ʁergun* = ‘to escape’

Translate into Tabasaran:

6. ‘you$_{\text{SG}}$ escaped’
7. ‘I got scared’
8. ‘I beat you$_{\text{SG}}$’
9. ‘we inflated’
10. ‘we stayed’

Solution

It is easy to notice that the arguments are marked at the end by the morphemes *č* (1PL), *čʷ* (2PL), *z* (1SG), *v* (2SG). The only challenge in this problem is figuring out the choice between the vowels *a* and *u* which follow them.

We notice that in transitive phrases (which have both subject and object), the subject always has the vowel *a*, while the object has the vowel *u*. Therefore, for transitive verbs, the structure of the phrase is $\boxed{\textit{V-SaOu}}$.

For intransitive verbs, we notice the examples *kčʷuχun-vu* and *kčʷuχun-za*, which have the same verbal stem in Tabasaran, but are translated as ‘to slip’ and ‘to sleigh’. Moreover, they differ only in the final vowel *a* vs. *u*. We notice that the difference between the two verbs is the degree of volition: ‘to slip’ is an involuntary or accidental action, while ‘to sleigh’ is used to describe a voluntary